

Indian Freedom Struggle & Prominent Leaders

Comprehensive Revision Notes — Structural Overview of Ideologies, Milestones & Leadership

The Indian Independence Movement was a series of historic milestones and multi-ideological struggles spanning nearly a century (1857–1947) to terminate the British Colonial Rule. It saw an evolution from armed rebellions to non-violent civil resistance, driven by leaders with diverse socio-political philosophies.

1. MAJOR EPOCHS OF THE FREEDOM MOVEMENT

The freedom struggle is broadly structured into three distinctive tactical operational phases:

The Early & Moderate Phase (1885–1905) Led by leaders like Dadabhai Naoroji and G.K. Gokhale. Focused on constitutional agitations, resolutions, and petitions within legal bounds to secure political representation.	The Extremist & Radical Phase (1905–1919) Sparked by the Partition of Bengal (1905). Championed by the Lal-Bal-Pal trio. Shifted target boundaries toward 'Swaraj' (Self-Rule) utilizing Boycott and Swadeshi campaigns.
The Gandhian Mass Era (1919–1947) Transformed the struggle into a massive public movement based on core frameworks of Satyagraha (Truth-force) and Ahimsa (Non-violence). Structured nationwide campaigns including Non-Cooperation (1920), Civil Disobedience (1930), and Quit India (1942).	

2. MATRIX OF PROMINENT FREEDOM FIGHTERS & KEY ACTIONS

Comprehensive profile catalog tracking prominent national leaders, their institutional alignments, and historical contributions.

Leader Details	Core Philosophy / Roles	Key Movements & Organizations	Historical Milestones
Mahatma Gandhi <i>Father of the Nation</i>	Ahimsa (Non-violence), Satyagraha, Gram Swaraj.	Indian National Congress (INC), Champaran Satyagraha (1917), Dandi March (1930).	Mobilized pan-Indian masses; negotiated the Gandhi-Irwin Pact.
Subhas Chandra Bose <i>Netaji</i>	Armed Revolution, Radical Nationalism.	Forward Bloc, Azad Hind Fauj (Indian National Army - INA).	Sought international alliances; liberated Indian soil via Northeast borders.
Bhagat Singh <i>Shaheed-e-Azam</i>	Revolutionary Socialism, Anti-Imperialism.	Naujawan Bharat Sabha, Hindustan Socialist Republican Association (HSRA).	Assembly Bombing (1929), execution at age 23 sparked national fury.
Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel <i>Iron Man of India</i>	Pragmatic Nationalism, Peasant Mobilization.	Bardoli Satyagraha (1928), INC Karachi Session President (1931).	Integrated 562 princely states into the unified Indian Union post-1947.
Jawaharlal Nehru <i>Chacha Nehru</i>	Democratic Socialism, Secularism, Modernism.	Home Rule League, All India States Peoples Conference.	Drafted 'Purna Swaraj' resolution (1929); first Prime Minister of India.
Bal Gangadhar Tilak <i>Lokmanya</i>	Radical Swarajism, Cultural Nationalism.	All India Home Rule League, Deccan Education Society.	Coinage of slogan: "Swaraj is my birthright and I shall have it."

Leader Details	Core Philosophy / Roles	Key Movements & Organizations	Historical Milestones
Rani Lakshmibai <i>Queen of Jhansi</i>	Armed Resistance, Armed Rebellion against Annexation.	Revolt of 1857 (First War of Indian Independence).	Fought fiercely against British forces under the 'Doctrine of Lapse'.
Dr. B.R. Ambedkar <i>Babasaheb</i>	Social Justice, Constitutional Rights, Anti-Casteism.	Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha, Scheduled Castes Federation.	Led Mahad Satyagraha (1927); Architect & Chairman of Constitution Drafting Panel.
Gopal Krishna Gokhale <i>Political Guru of Gandhi</i>	Moderate Constitutionalism, Social Reform.	Servants of India Society (1905), Imperial Legislative Council.	Exposed colonial fiscal exploitation through detailed budgetary analysis.
V.O. Chidambaram Pillai <i>Kappalottiya Thamizhan</i>	Swadeshi Enterprise, Economic Nationalism.	Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company (1906), Coral Mill Strike.	Broke British maritime monopoly by launching indigenous Indian shipping lines.
Sarojini Naidu <i>Nightingale of India</i>	Women Empowerment, Civil Rights.	Dharasana Satyagraha (1930), Women's Indian Association.	First Indian woman to become INC President (1925 Kanpur Session).

3. INSTITUTIONAL LANDMARKS & STRATEGIC TURNING POINTS

The operational course of the freedom movement was reshaped significantly by several critical turning points:

- The Revolt of 1857 (Sepoy Mutiny):** The first widespread armed uprising against the British East India Company. It led to the direct dissolution of Company rule and transferred formal sovereignty directly to the British Crown via the Government of India Act 1858.
- Jallianwala Bagh Massacre (1919):** The brutal, unprovoked firing on a peaceful gathering in Amritsar ordered by General Dyer. It acted as the absolute turning point, transforming Mahatma Gandhi from a loyalist petitioner into an uncompromising anti-colonial activist, leading directly to the Non-Cooperation Movement.
- The Purna Swaraj Declaration (1929):** Promulgated during the Lahore Session of the Indian National Congress under Nehru's presidency. It shifted the official political goal boundary from "Dominion Status" to "Complete Independence" (Purna Swaraj).

4. REVOLUTIONARY & MILITARY SPLINTERS

Parallel to the mainstream non-violent campaign sat highly organized revolutionary factions who believed armed resistance was the only method capable of overthrowing colonial administration.

- Hindustan Socialist Republican Association (HSRA)**
 Founded by Chandrashekhhar Azad, Bhagat Singh, and Sukhdev. Transitioned Indian revolutionary activity away from individual targeted actions toward an organized mass socialist uprising.
- The Indian National Army (INA / Azad Hind Fauj)**
 Revitalized by Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose in Singapore. It engineered a direct military assault against British forces on the Indo-Burma front, weakening the internal security loyalty of Indian soldiers within the British Indian Army.

5. KEY IDEOLOGICAL PUBLICATIONS & JOURNALS

Print media served as a fundamental vehicle for mass mobilization and ideological dissemination across provincial lines:

Publication Name	Founder / Key Editor	Ideological Core Objective
Kesari (Marathi) & Mahratta (English)	Bal Gangadhar Tilak	Critiqued colonial policies; propagated anti-imperialist views among common citizens.
Harijan & Young India	Mahatma Gandhi	Promoted social reforms, Hindu-Muslim unity, and eradication of untouchability.
Al-Hilal (Urdu Journal)	Maulana Abul Kalam Azad	Critiqued British rule and urged Indian Muslims to join the mainstream secular struggle.
Bande Mataram	Aurobindo Ghosh	Propagated radical nationalism and the spiritual philosophy of complete Swaraj.

History Revision Matrix — Structured Specifically for Competitive Civil Services and General Academic Reference.